



Grand European

## Welcome & Tour Tips

Good to have you here — this page covers some practical guidance and useful things to know before we meet in London and begin our journey across Europe together.

Not everything here will be new to you — think of this as a useful reference to check back on before travelling. Use the navigation below to jump to any section.

This is a personal guide from your Travel Director — for your official itinerary and inclusions, refer to your Trafalgar documents.

### Before we meet in London

-  Know where you are staying and where we are meeting on Day 1.
-  Have a rough plan for getting from the airport to your hotel before you leave home.
-  Keep passports, medications, chargers and valuables in your day bag rather than packed away in your suitcase.



## Our first day

We begin with an early Eurostar journey from London to Belgium before continuing to Bruges. It's a memorable first day of the tour, and once we meet in London I'll guide everyone through things as we go.



## Passport & essentials

Keep your passport, medications, chargers and any important items in your day bag rather than packed away inside your main suitcase.

Having those essentials easy to reach makes the first travel day much smoother.



## Luggage

There is a short walk through St Pancras before boarding the train, so a practical suitcase that rolls easily tends to make the morning feel smoother and easier.

Most people find that packing a little lighter makes the journey more comfortable overall.



## Ready to begin exploring

We arrive into Bruges and begin sightseeing fairly soon after arrival, so it is best to think of Day 1 as an active touring afternoon rather than a hotel arrival afternoon.

Comfortable clothes and practical walking shoes make a big difference here — Bruges is beautiful, but also very cobblestoned.

Keep anything you may want during the afternoon in your day bag rather than packed away in your suitcase.



## Final details

I'll send another email the night before we meet with the important details for our first morning together and the Eurostar journey to Belgium.

For now, the main thing is simply arriving into London knowing where you need to be and keeping your essentials easy to access.



## Arrival & planning

This is one of those proper classic European journeys — multiple countries, changing scenery, and a lot packed into a relatively short period of time. A little preparation before departure goes a long way.



### Check your joining details

Your welcome email and official documents confirm your London departure hotel, departure time from London, and Eurostar details. Keep those easy to access before and during travel.



### Luggage prep

- Label your main suitcase clearly before leaving home.
- A suitcase that rolls easily and is comfortable for you to travel with will make things much smoother across the tour.
- Pack essentials (passport, medications, phone charger) in your day bag, not in your main case.



### Travel documents

- Your **passport** must be valid for the full duration of the tour — check your government's official travel advice for entry requirements across all countries on the itinerary.
- Keep your passport in your day bag or jacket on departure morning — you will need it for Eurostar check-in and both UK and French immigration at St Pancras. Do not pack it in your main suitcase.
- Your **Eurostar tickets** will be provided by me in the hotel lobby on the morning of departure. You do not need to print anything in advance.

**Entry & travel documents:** Entry and visa requirements can vary depending on your nationality. Your Trafalgar documents include guidance, and I recommend checking your government's official travel advice before departure to be safe.



## On the coach

The coach will be our moving base between destinations. A few simple habits help keep things comfortable, safe and pleasant for everyone travelling together.



**Seat rotation** happens daily. I will explain the system clearly at the start of the tour.



There is often a **WC on board**, and we also plan regular comfort stops along the way.



**Mobility & boarding:** There are steps when getting on and off the coach, so please take your time and use the handrail.



**Snacks are absolutely fine.** For general comfort and safety on a moving vehicle, it's best to avoid hot food, hot drinks, ice creams, and anything very messy or strongly scented while on the coach.



Bring a **small day bag** with what you may need during the day. Main suitcases stay in the coach hold until hotel arrival on travel days.



**Carry-on space on the coach is limited.** Smaller soft bags such as backpacks or tote-style bags work best overhead or under the seat. Soft day bags are generally much easier and more comfortable on the coach than wheel-based carry-ons.



**Seatbelts:** For your safety, please ensure your seatbelt is fastened whenever you are seated and keep it on throughout the journey.



Please be mindful of **general hygiene**. Clean hands and a bit of awareness go a long way in shared spaces. If you're feeling unwell, just be considerate of others.



## What to pack

Most people find they pack more than they actually use. Europe rewards practical, comfortable layers — conditions can vary quite a bit across the tour, particularly between mountain regions and southern destinations.

### Essentials

-  Comfortable walking shoes — essential from departure day (Bruges cobblestones) and throughout the tour
-  Light layers for varying climates and elevations
-  A compact, packable waterproof jacket
-  Sun protection — particularly useful for southern destinations, higher elevations, and longer sightseeing days
-  A small day bag
-  Power adapters — UK and Europe use different plugs, and Switzerland and Italy can be different again. A universal travel adapter with USB/USB-C ports is the easiest option.

[Power plug guide](#)

### Packing smarter

-  Think practical rather than "just in case" — and leave a little room for things you pick up along the way.
-  Layers are key — the tour covers a wide range of climates, from coastal Belgium to the Swiss Alps and southern destinations. A light layer + compact waterproof covers most situations.
-  Good shoes matter most on this tour — cobblestones, hills, and varied terrain across every destination.
-  Optional: a reusable drink bottle. Collapsible or slim styles are easiest to carry on coach days.
-  Optional: wired headphones with a 3.5mm jack, useful with our walking-tour audio devices.

 **Luggage allowance:** 1 suitcase (max 23kg / 50lbs) plus 1 soft hand-luggage bag. The hand-luggage bag should be soft-sided (backpack/tote style), without wheels or a telescopic handle. Label your bags clearly before arrival — and remember, on London departure morning you will briefly manage your main case through St Pancras. A suitcase that rolls easily and feels manageable for you will make the journey much more comfortable.

 **Tip:** At many hotels, your main suitcase is delivered to your room by the hotel porters after arrival. This can sometimes take a little while when large groups arrive together, so it is worth keeping medications, chargers, toiletries, or anything you may want immediately in your day bag or hand luggage.

 **Laundry:** On a tour of this length, people are usually glad to know there is a chance to freshen up the wardrobe. We can generally manage a service wash at one of our multi-night stops — I will let you know the best opportunity once we are underway.



## What to expect from the weather

This tour covers a wide range of climates and elevations — from northern Europe and alpine regions through to warmer southern destinations. Conditions can change quite quickly across the journey, which is why layers are always the safest approach.



## What to expect

Northern Europe can be mild and changeable, Switzerland cooler at altitude, and southern destinations warmer depending on the season and local conditions. A light layer nearly always earns its place in the day bag.

Some days will feel relaxed and easy-going, others fast-moving and memorable. That variety is part of what makes a journey like this feel special by the end.



## What usually helps

A compact packable waterproof is more useful than a heavy one — you will probably not need it every day, but it is good to have. Sun protection matters more on this tour than most. Treat forecasts as a guide rather than a guarantee.

One of the joys of this journey is how quickly the scenery, climate, architecture and atmosphere can change across Europe. Come ready to enjoy the variety.



## Staying connected on tour

I use WhatsApp for reminders and day-to-day updates while we are travelling. Joining is optional, and it works alongside your official documents and welcome email.

**1**

Download WhatsApp before you travel if you do not already use it — either from the link below or directly from your phone's app store.

[Download WhatsApp](#)**2**

Set up your profile and verify your number.

**3**

Save my number in your phone from the welcome email or with the links above.

**4**

Send me a quick WhatsApp message with your name so I know you are set up before the tour begins.



**Travelling with someone?** It helps if both of you message me, just in case phones get separated during the trip.

Most hotels and many public places offer free Wi-Fi throughout the tour. If you plan to rely on mobile data across multiple countries, it is worth checking international roaming options with your provider before travel. Some people use an eSIM as a simple alternative for staying connected across borders.



## Practical notes

A few practical notes that tend to come up — worth a quick read before you travel.



### The pace of the tour

This is one of those proper classic European journeys — multiple countries, changing landscapes, different cultures, and a lot packed into a relatively short period of time.

One morning you may wake up beside the Rhine, another in the Alps, another preparing to wander through an Italian city.

You will settle into the rhythm of the tour surprisingly quickly once we are underway.

The pace is part of the experience — and also part of what makes this journey feel so memorable by the end.



### Walking

You will cover a surprising amount of ground across this tour — from cobblestones and old town centres through to station platforms, scenic viewpoints and longer sightseeing days.

Comfortable walking shoes genuinely make the experience more enjoyable — especially once the days start blending together across different cities and countries.



### Hotel styles vary

One night you may be in a modern business-style hotel, the next in a historic property in an old European town.

That variety is part of the character of a journey like this.



### Air conditioning

Coaches are air conditioned, and many hotels and public venues will have cooling, especially in warmer parts of Europe.

That said, Europe is not always built around strong air conditioning in the same way some travellers may be used to elsewhere. Some historic hotels, mountain properties, or older buildings may have more limited systems — particularly during warmer periods. Reception can sometimes help, but a bit of flexibility goes a long way on a journey like this.



### **Included meals**

Breakfast is included daily and some dinners are provided. On included meal days, timings are set to keep the itinerary running smoothly, so punctuality is appreciated.

### **Travelling as a group**

Touring as a group works best when everyone is mindful of shared timings — I will make sure things run smoothly from my end.

### **Your Driver**

Your Driver plays a huge role in keeping the journey safe, smooth, and enjoyable throughout the tour.

By the end of the trip, most groups realise very quickly just how much skill, patience and organisation goes into moving a journey like this across Europe.

### **Security**

Keep passports, cards, and valuables secure and close to you, especially in busy tourist areas such as Rome, Venice, and Florence. A little awareness in crowded places goes a long way.

### **Money, cards & currency**

Card payments are widely accepted throughout the tour, but a small amount of cash is still useful for gratuities, local markets, smaller cafes, and the occasional place that prefers cash.

We begin in London with Pounds Sterling (£ / GBP). Most countries on the tour use the Euro (€), while Switzerland uses the Swiss Franc (CHF).

A small ATM withdrawal on arrival is usually simpler than exchanging large amounts before travel. Optional experiences can be paid by card or cash.

### ★ **Optional experiences**

Some of the best memories people take home from this tour actually come from the optional experiences along the way.

They are designed to complement the itinerary rather than feel separate from it — and they often end up being the stories people still talk about afterwards.

I will explain what is available once we are underway. There is never any pressure.

### **Gratuities**

Some gratuities are included in your tour price — restaurant staff and hotel porters, for example. Tips for your Travel Director and Driver are separate unless pre-paid.

If you have pre-paid — thank you, it is genuinely appreciated.

Guidance on appropriate amounts is in your Trafalgar documents — or just ask me on tour.

If you are unsure whether gratuities are pre-paid, check your tour voucher or booking confirmation.



## Important contact details

Save these before you travel — they are harder to find when you are already on the move.

### Joel Plunkett

#### Phone / WhatsApp

**+44 7496 055 950**

WhatsApp is usually the easiest way to reach me during the trip.

You do not need to remember everything on this page — once the tour begins, I will guide everyone through things step by step.

 [Follow along on Instagram →](#)

 [Visit my homepage →](#)

 [Email me →](#)

### Questions before the tour?

Before the tour begins I may occasionally be travelling or finishing another tour, but I will always get back to you as soon as I can.

Once the tour begins, things generally become very straightforward — I will guide everyone through the day-to-day logistics as we travel.



#### **Urgent or time-sensitive before departure?**

For anything that needs immediate attention before Day 1, please check your welcome email for European Guest Services contact details.

For peace of mind, save my number and European Guest Services now, and keep your official joining instructions somewhere easy to find before departure.



### Final note

Once the tour begins, things usually become very straightforward day to day. If you are ever unsure about anything along the way, just ask.



See you in London.

Want this page offline? [Click here to print or save as PDF](#) — or press Cmd+P (Mac) / Ctrl+P (Windows) and choose "Save as PDF". On mobile, use the link.

A personal guide from your Travel Director. For official timings, inclusions and operational details before the tour, refer to your Trafalgar documents.